

Report Part Title: Hizbollah in the Lebanese Domestic Arena

Report Title: New Rules of the Game

Report Subtitle: Israel and Hizbollah after the Withdrawal from Lebanon

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Institute for National Security Studies (2004)

Stable URL: <http://www.jstor.com/stable/resrep08962.11>

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Chapter 7

Hizbollah in the Lebanese Domestic Arena

The preoccupation with Hizbollah as an organization with military and terrorist dimensions tends to overlook the economic and social dimensions to the organization within the Lebanese domestic arena, which in fact may be expected to increase in importance the longer the status quo abides between Israel and Hizbollah and a glaring deterioration does not ensue. Hizbollah's public announcement of its concern for Lebanon's economy and tourist industry is only partially representative of its interests since, as a movement with social dimensions, it is careful to champion Lebanon's economic plight. Indeed, the leader of the Hizbollah faction in parliament, Muhammad Ra'd, announced that in addition to the struggle with Israel, Hizbollah and Lebanon are waging war on the socio-economic level:

We face another confrontation and struggle in the domestic arena, namely, the economic war, the embargo, the budget deficit, recession, cash shortage, and rising unemployment . . . This is a war that requires planning and everyone's cooperation since we are struggling on two fronts simultaneously, and the loss of one means the loss of the other.¹

The question raised here is to what extent Hizbollah's political strength serves its military prowess and ability to preserve the option of an armed struggle against Israel. Apparently by anchoring its roots in Lebanon's parliamentary, social, and economic arenas, Hizbollah has built itself a safety net of organizational legitimacy independent of its military dimension. The preservation of Hizbollah's legitimacy depends on its degree of success in supporting economic recovery and in providing welfare services to its constituency and to other needy publics. Hassan Nasrallah has noted that providing for the families of fallen comrades serves as "the backing and continuation of the resistance option."²

Domestic and Economic Intervention

Even before Israel's withdrawal, Hizbollah was actively engaged in providing welfare services through agencies such as the "Martyr's Agency" (*Mu'asasat al-Shahid*), "The Agency for the Injured" (*Mu'asasat al-Jarih*), and "The Jihad for Construction" (*Jihad al-Binaa'*),³ taking pride in these institutional endeavors. In a publication for the Martyr's Agency televised on al-Manar, one clip described how the agency supported a little boy from the time his father, a Hizbollah fighter, was killed, through the boy's university studies and training as a doctor in a hospital.⁴ The Construction Agency has assisted poor farmers by instructing them in agricultural techniques, soil development, and livestock breeding.⁵

But the connection between Hizbollah and its electorate runs much deeper. Beirut's southern neighborhoods comprise one of the largest Shiite concentrations in Lebanon, and are both an important Hizbollah stronghold and the location of the majority of the organization's offices. The area is densely populated (500,000 inhabitants, according to Na'im Qasim), noticeably run-down – the Shiites settled there en masse, in part after fleeing north and abandoning their homes in the southern war zone – and for this reason has been given the name "Misery Strip." In his book, Qasim relates that since March 1991 Hizbollah has volunteered to supply drinking water daily to the residents of South Beirut using 110 water tanks that hold 300,000 liters. Also, between 1988 and 1991, Hizbollah took over South Beirut's sanitation system, "assuming responsibility for an area neglected by the state."⁶

After the IDF withdrawal, the organization established the Islamic Health Organization, which included nine health centers, sixteen clinics, and three mobile clinics providing health services for fifty-one villages. In 2001 the clinics treated 111,077 civilians, and supplied free medication and health services to pupils in eighty-eight schools. Hizbollah also offered free educational assistance to thousands of pupils in Lebanon.⁷

According to Timur Goksel, after the IDF withdrawal the organization expanded its activity in the evacuated areas. For example, it took over the hospital in Bint Jbayl, which it still runs, and set up clinics and aid centers for farmers. Goksel mentions Hizbollah's scholarship program, research grants, and financial assistance for housing for families of Hizbollah fighters who were killed, wounded, or disabled. "According to this system Hizbollah holds on to its people. It cares for them. If someone is killed in battle, the family knows it will be provided for – perhaps even better than if the man were alive. They receive full housing, scholarships, medical treatment – everything is guaranteed, and [Hizbollah] proves that it is capable of accomplishing this."⁸

A recent example of Hizbollah's efforts for the benefit of residents was its damage control following a severe snowstorm in late February 2003. The Lebanese described the storm as the worst in five decades. The Shiite center in the Lebanon Valley suffered severe losses, including fatalities, when lands and entire villages were flooded. Nasrallah reproached the Lebanese government for its negligence and declared that "dealing with the results of the present situation amounts to a jihad."⁹ He called on the members of his organization and all its institutions to volunteer in aiding the storm victims. The media reported the mobilization of hundreds of Hizbollah activists who removed snow from the roads leading to dozens of villages.¹⁰ A Hizbollah delegation that came to assess the damage in the Lebanon Valley distributed staples such as food, bread, and oil, provided medical treatment, and transferred the sick to hospitals.¹¹

Beyond its investment in welfare and other assistance to the local population, Hizbollah is attuned to the broader national concern with economic revival. Overall, Lebanon's politicians, media, and public have been ardently engaged in the country's economic affairs in an effort to attract investors. An outstanding example of this was the near "national celebration" organized in Beirut on the eve of the opening of a Movenpick hotel in early July 2002. The hotel's opening was attended by the Lebanese leadership, including President Emile Lahud, and broadcast live with full coverage on a number of Lebanese television stations – hardly a common phenomenon in most countries. Another example of the nation's economic preoccupation was Beirut TV's short of crowds applauding a young man who paid his restaurant bill in Lebanese pounds, rather than in dollars, as his friends generally did. Similarly, a TV advertisement for the Middle East Bank on Tele Liban enthusiastically described the rehabilitation of Lebanon and its national status. The clip concluded with the announcements that "Lebanon has reemerged better than ever" and "all of us pledge our trust in Lebanon."

Operating within this environment, which will probably continue in the near future, Hizbollah's military actions could be perceived as running counter to the nation's interests. The possibility of an Israeli attack against the Lebanese infrastructure in response to Hizbollah provocation could shatter the atmosphere of stability that the government is taking pains to restore to the country. Such counterproductive repercussions to the organization are probably what motivate it to keep many of its activities anonymous. An indictment against Hizbollah would hurt the organization and brand it with the image of traitor to its pledge to protect the state and foster Lebanese economic growth.

In the coming years Prime Minister Hariri will have to achieve maximum equanimity and stability in Lebanon in order to advance his economic plans. He has tried to launch the privatization of large government companies, including cellular phone companies, in order to reduce the country's foreign debt. Hizbollah could interfere with Hariri's – and Lebanon's – efforts at extricating the country from the economic crisis by carrying out military acts that would sabotage Lebanon's image as a safe arena for investment. Some countries would be eager to invest in Lebanon if Hizbollah displayed utmost restraint. In late November 2002, twenty-seven countries and international organizations participated in the Paris 2 Convention in the French capital. By the end of the meeting, loans to Lebanon amounted to over \$4.4 billion, a pledge that received wide coverage and high-profile debate in the media. It seems that Lebanon was exempted from political payment in the form of tightening the hold on Hizbollah in exchange for the loans; nevertheless Hizbollah will have to take the political track into consideration since it claims that its military might is what protects Lebanon from Israel. Now the organization will have to stand by its words.

Hizbollah generally endeavors to participate in the public discussion on the economy, and devotes programs on Hizbollah TV to this issue.¹² Nasrallah has often sought to create for himself the image of a leader whose highest priority is the Lebanese economy. Thus, in a speech on May 25, 2002, he declared:

Once, in a debate on the use of resistance, I told officials that “we care about the nation, the state, and the future more than you think.” Why is that? Because when the state is threatened by security, military, and political dangers and economic collapse, God forbid, people who possess income, capital, companies, [and who have] children, mansions, and homes abroad leave [the country]. They hold dual citizenship. It's very simple. They collect the rest of their family here and leave the country. [But] our homes, graves, life, death, honor, and humiliation – remain here. Where else can we go?¹³

In fact, over 2003 Hizbollah became one of the key parties warning against further economic deterioration, and towards the end of the year, it cautioned that the national debt could reach \$35 billion by the end of 2004.¹⁴

At the same time, Hizbollah harbors considerable reservations over the prime minister's plans for efficiency and privatization, because of the thousands of citizens who are expected to lose their jobs following the privatization of companies. Indeed, Hizbollah leaders endeavor to make their voices heard whenever labor layoffs threaten the citizens. This dimension has become perhaps even more characteristic of Hizbollah

activity since it lost South Lebanon as its main field of military operations in May 2000. For example, in June 2001, Hizbollah, Amal, and other movements such as the Syrian Socialist National Party (SSNP) were caught up in a crisis that grew out of the intention to dismiss 1450 workers of Middle East Airlines due to deficits and the urgent need to streamline the company. Ra'd warned the government that Hizbollah had the power to take the struggle "to the street," but would avoid doing this, despite its mass following, out of awareness of the dangers involved. By the same token, the organization rejected charges that its protest over the workers' lay-off sprang from the fact that many of its supporters were employed in the company.¹⁵

Beyond the privatization crisis, Hizbollah raised its flag over other issues, the first of which was the government's decision to terminate hashish growing in the Lebanon Valley. Hizbollah immediately rejected this plan and proposed that the government purchase the crop from the growers or find them an alternative source of livelihood. Two months later, in September 2001, Hizbollah fought against the government proposal for a gas hike in order to generate money to pay off the state's debt. In mid-2002 the organization protested the government decision to declare trucks running on crude oil illegal.

One example of Hizbollah's PR management in the shadow of the economic imperative is illustrated by its low profile during the summer tourist season in 2001 and 2002 (the summer of 2000 is less relevant because until the three IDF soldiers were kidnapped on October 7, 2000, the entire southern front was quiet). At the start of the 2001 tourist season, the head of the Hizbollah parliamentary faction, Muhammad Ra'd, announced that his organization would take the economy and tourist industry into consideration when operating against Israel:

At our last meeting with Hariri we realized he is convinced that there is no possibility that Israel will go to war, and that it is [only] engaged in scare-mongering. But the side that does not wage war inflicts painful blows. This does not imply that war does not exist. We agree on the question of Israel's ability to inflict painful blows, and cause serious divisions of opinion regarding resistance . . . We must be wary of this; and the resistance is mindful of Israel's [machinations] and what could happen to Lebanese society and the economic situation . . . Let us assume that we are in the summer season and a stream of tourists [has arrived] in Lebanon. Would the resistance proceed to ruin this? The resistance will act befitting the present conditions and will not be responsible for destroying the summer vacation season.¹⁶

When the 2002 tourist season began, Ra'd declared that Hizbollah wishes Lebanon success and prosperity, which it indeed subsequently enjoyed.¹⁷ On August 29, 2002, Hizbollah renewed its activity on Mt. Dov, and in the mortar fire on IDF strongholds – the first operation after four months – IDF Sgt. Ophir Mishal was fatally wounded. Several days later the daily *al-Mustaqbal* published a commentary under the heading “Objectives of the New ‘Farms’ Operation and its Significance,” signed by Qasim Qasir. Regarding the timing of the operation, the Lebanese commentator quoted “observers” who counted seven factors, most of them connected with the regional situation, especially with developments in the Iraqi and Palestinian arenas. But the first consideration was that the tourist season was over and Hizbollah had not been interested in sabotaging the country’s atmosphere while tourists were vacationing.¹⁸ For its part, the Lebanese government anticipates increased tourism in the coming years. In December 2002, an annual contract was signed with the American television network CNN for broadcasting advertisements that promoted Lebanon’s image as a tourist attraction. Minister of Commerce and Industry Basel Felihan announced, “We are discussing the beginning of a broader program that emphasizes Lebanon’s beauty and potential as a tourist site.”¹⁹

Furthermore, Hizbollah labors to present itself as a corrupt-free organization, motivated by popular wellbeing rather than any private incentives. Thus, Hizbollah leaders have continuously criticized the state’s leadership for the blatant corruption in government corridors that contributes heavily to the country’s economic plight. On June 12, 2001, Na'im Qasim declared that Lebanon was going through an economic test, and he called on the government to put an end to the “greedy hand.” A few months later, on November 9, Muhammad Yazbak, a Hizbollah parliamentarian, warned of a popular uprising if the Lebanese government did not end the widespread graft. Hizbollah regards its own clean image as a matter of highest value. In early January 2003, Nasrallah stated that it was impossible to hold a meeting then between the organization and Prime Minister Hariri because of the burning insult Hizbollah had dispatched not long before with Hariri’s accusation that the organization had attempted to transfer to its own coffers budgets intended for developing South Beirut.²⁰ Nasrallah’s response:

The worst charge was our desire for compensation in order to obtain money for the Hizbollah budget. This was grossly insulting. You can tell me that this may be accepted practice in Lebanese politics. From our point of view – from my personal point of view and that of my Hizbollah brothers – this is unacceptable. You can call us extremists and terrorists – that won’t anger

us. But to call us thieves? Not in the past, not in the present, and not in the future. Whoever needs money – we are ready to give it to him.²¹

Hizbollah's integration into the Lebanese political system was accompanied by internal dissension that led to violent clashes with the former secretary-general Subhi Tufayli. The organization believed it had to prove that it remained faithful to its social promises after entering the state establishment. In addition, its involvement in the Lebanese political arena continued for a different reason: the continuous struggle with its rival, Amal, for the loyalty of Lebanon's Shiite community. In South Lebanon the rivalry is expressed in the "battle" of the welfare agencies. Hizbollah agencies have unfolded a protective umbrella over the population, while Amal controls the Southern Council, responsible for investment and development in South Lebanon. The secular organization Amal, whose goal was to oust the IDF from Lebanon but not to destroy the State of Israel, was considered closer to Syria. Hizbollah, the Islamic organization, was closer to Iran in all areas, including ideology.²²

In the wake of the Israeli withdrawal from South Lebanon, an intermingling of Amal and Hizbollah flags could be seen across the border, but the differences and rivalries between the two groups remained intact and the "beginning of a beautiful friendship" never materialized. Since then, dozens of violent incidents between supporters of the two organizations have been reported. Sometimes fistfights have been accompanied with gunfire, and in at least three cases clashes led to fatalities.²³ The central government was forced to intervene in May 2001 to prevent the holding of two separate rallies in South Lebanon on the first anniversary of the Israeli withdrawal. Both sides acceded to the request and took part in a state-run affair that was attended by the president and prime minister.

At the same time, the two organizations are capable of working in tandem, especially when this is in Syria's interest. In September 2001, they joined forces in elections to 115 local councils in South Lebanon – the first elections in South Lebanon in thirty-eight years. The Amal-Hizbollah pact swept up a majority of votes in ninety of the councils.²⁴ Hizbollah's advantage over Amal could be said to lie in the fact that South Lebanon's liberation has been mainly engraved with Hizbollah's name. Although the power of this trump card is fading as time passes, the organization compensates for this by preserving the "resistance" option and especially by presenting itself as the ultimate defender of Lebanon against the Israeli threat. Competition between Hizbollah and Amal in the political arena could serve as a stimulus for Hizbollah to highlight its "resistance" dimension further. Already in the

late nineties, Amal-Hizbollah rivalry created an increase in military activity against Israel by both organizations.

In recent months the need to take local exigencies into consideration has added a renewed relevancy in Hizbollah's "opening up" toward the Lebanese and even international arenas. Nasrallah's rare participation in the opening address of the Francophonic Conference in Beirut, the publication of Na'im Qasim's book, which is designed to justify the organization and its goals, and the announcement of preparations to update and moderate its political platform are all signs of the organization's propensity toward marketing a new image, one more sympathetic to the host environment. In accordance with this trend, in November 2002 Nasrallah asked to convene a quiet, internal Lebanese dialogue to resolve disputes in society and unify the nation. At the same time, he also referred to the existence of differences of opinion over his organization's activity,²⁵ an indication that Nasrallah is aware of the lack of consensus concerning Hizbollah's military operations. Thus, the Hizbollah leader is trying to convince his listeners that his organization operates with the purest of Lebanese motives in mind:

At the very least, we are engaged in a national enterprise. The resistance has never been and never will be a partisan enterprise, a regional enterprise, or an ethnic-community enterprise. It is an authentic national enterprise. Even today when the resistance operates, it acts according to national considerations. Whoever thinks that the timing of some of [the organization's] positions or operations is planned by someone in the internal arena errs. I spoke about these things in the past and . . . in closed meetings with some of these people . . . You and I may differ over a particular political issue, an economic or social [issue], or over particular elections – municipal, parliamentary, trade unions, etc. These arguments are legitimate, but when it comes to the resistance, I reiterate that these differences of opinion have no background, role, or place.²⁶

Hizbollah's increased involvement in the domestic arena can be expected to continue. Nasrallah's call for promoting an internal Lebanese dialogue was not accidental. Hizbollah sources acknowledge that it was the reflection of an internal debate over the question of the organization's orientation and policy on current domestic affairs.²⁷ The unanswered question is: which "crossroads" loom on the organization's path that will present it with a wide range of possible directions and as such will impact on Hizbollah's influence in Lebanon.

Promoting “Resistance” as a Defense of Lebanon

In explaining the effectiveness of anti-aircraft fire against IDF planes, Nasrallah claims that it safeguards Lebanon’s stability and security. Indeed, the theme of the organization’s armament and military operations as protection for Lebanon against the Israeli menace is a recurring one. At the time of the IDF withdrawal, Hizbollah protested calls to disarm the organization, claiming in part that in the event of aggression, the central government could not expect support from the Security Council and the international community to enforce an Israeli retreat.

Relating to Israel’s charges that Hizbollah has stockpiled thousands of rockets and Jerusalem’s warning to Lebanon to demilitarize Hizbollah, Nasrallah declared that “one day Lebanon will need” the “resistance infrastructure” and its weapons.²⁸ In the same vein he continued, “Whoever wants to defend Lebanon must preserve the resistance in the south [because] we stand as a powerful dam before the enemy’s threats against our land and country.”²⁹ In March 2003 Nasrallah felt it necessary to reveal that a sabotage squad had been arrested in the border town of Hula, and in its possession were explosive charges supplied by Israel.³⁰

Hizbollah’s position has won support from various circles in the Lebanese government, even if not from the majority of the establishment. For example, Defense Minister Khalil al-Harawi promised that every Israeli “violation” would be answered “by the security triad composed of the Lebanese and Syrian armies and the ‘resistance.’”³¹ He drew a clear line between Hizbollah and the stability of Lebanon, saying:

There are diplomats who tell us, “you built a state and its institutions and liberated your land, then why do you still desire a confrontation? It is necessary for you to dismantle Hizbollah and deploy the army in the south so that your conditions will improve.” Similar ideas were also voiced by a number of Lebanese political parties who forgot that our situation was excellent in every way in 1974, but this did not prevent the crisis of 1975. We reply to these statements by [posing] the question: Do you want us to return to the situation of 1974, and begin the confrontation again?

Nasrallah attributes capabilities to his organization that the Lebanese army lacks, thus explaining the absurdity of deploying the Lebanese army along the border with Israel. On December 1, 2001 he stated that Hizbollah’s presence on the border is “a stabilizing factor [that guarantees] regional security” since the Lebanese army “is

unable to respond to every attack.” He also noted that “whoever advocates dispatching the army to the south is misinformed, since the army is already deployed in the region, but is not qualified to respond to every aggression. That is the nature of the sensitive circumstances.”³² Hizbollah’s reinforcement with enormous weapons stockpiles has additional importance since the message is also absorbed in the domestic arena, and the task of disarming the organization will undoubtedly be more difficult for anyone who might consider it.

The chance to justify the claim that its deterrence protects Lebanon from Israeli aggression presented itself in 2002 during the Wazzani project crisis. Although Amal initiated the project, it was Hizbollah that gathered the credit as Lebanon’s main protector in the affair, garnering cross-the-board political and public support. The deputy secretary-general later announced that, “Had there not been the likelihood of an Islamic resistance response, Israel would have disrupted the pumping, but the enemy knows that Hizbollah was serious in its [intention to respond] and was prepared for an immediate reaction.”³³ Even before Nasrallah announced that his organization would respond instantly to Israeli interference with the Wazzani project, one of the leading figures in the Christian camp, the head of the al-Kata’ib (Phalangists) Party, Karim Pakradouni, delivered the same message. Needless to say, Pakradouni and the majority of the Christian camp were not traditionally Hizbollah’s political ally (although by the end of 2003 they had grown much closer). Yet on October 14, 2002, Pakradouni predicted that Israel would sit quietly and do nothing to excite the sector; otherwise Hizbollah would respond with a barrage of missiles across the border.³⁴

In January 2003, in a token gesture to the residents of the town of Wazzani, Hizbollah handed out ten thousand liters of oil free of charge. This was done as an incentive to the people not to flee the village despite what the Lebanese perceived as an Israeli threat to take action in the near future.³⁵ A similar gesture was made to the inhabitants of South Lebanon’s Hasbaya region in March 2003 as the war in Iraq approached and the fear of an Israeli attack increased. In this case, Hizbollah set up a field clinic in a town that, according to the residents, “had been neglected by the government.”³⁶